

FileBank WorkFlow

Administrator Manual

Step-by-step instructions for setting up forms, approval chains and people, and looking after requests

This manual is for people with the Admin role. Each task is a short list of steps with a picture of the screen; the button or box a step talks about is outlined in red. Reference tables (controls, formulas, audit events, emails) follow the tasks in each chapter. The pictures show a demonstration organisation, Riverside Academy, with made-up people such as Alex Admin and Maria Manager. Everyday submitting and approving is in the User Manual; server installation is in docs/DEPLOYMENT-IIS.md.

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CHAPTER 1

How it works

As an administrator you see an extra menu at the top of every page: **Dashboard, Requests, Forms, Lookups, Reports, Users, Audit log** and **Settings**. Everything there belongs to **your organisation only** - your forms, your people, your requests. Other organisations on the same installation are invisible to you, and you are invisible to them.

You look after	Where
Forms, their fields and their approval chains	Forms
People and their roles (Submitter, Approver, Admin)	Users
Requests that are stuck or overdue: remind, reassign, delegate, cancel	Dashboard, Requests
Reference data for drop-downs (schools, departments...)	Lookups
Figures, Excel exports and the PDF archive	Reports, Requests > Export PDFs
Answering "who did what, and when"	Audit log
Your name, logo, colour, who may register, email sender	Settings

What administrators cannot do - by design

- Approve or reject on someone else's behalf. Only the assigned approver or a delegate can decide. (Make yourself a delegate if you must act; the audit log records it.)
- Edit a submission or a completed approver section. Completed sections never change.
- Reopen a **Rejected**, **Approved** or **Cancelled** request. These are final; the submitter submits a new request.
- Change or delete audit log entries or stored PDFs.
- See anything belonging to another organisation.

NOTE

You can also be an approver in a chain, and a submitter. Click **Approvals** in the top-left to see your own approval inbox and submissions, as for any other user.

Site addresses

Your organisation has **its own address**, and everybody in it uses that one address - for example <https://acme.vwf.filebankinc.com>. The administrator pages are under **/admin** on it (<https://acme.vwf.filebankinc.com/admin>); only people with the Admin role can open them. Links in emails always use your organisation's address.

CHAPTER 2

Getting started

Open the administrator pages

You need: an account with the Admin role.

- 1 Sign in at your organisation's address with your email and 6-digit password key, as described in the User Manual.
- 2 The **Dashboard** opens, with the administrator menu across the top. Click a menu item to go to that page.

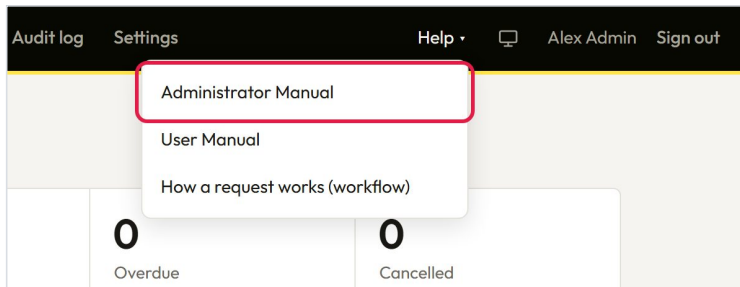
Form	Step	Decisions	Average time to decide
Purchase Request	1. Line manager	3	0 min
Purchase Request	2. Finance	2	0 min
Purchase Request	3. Director	1	0 min

RESULT

You are in the administrator pages. **Approvals** (top-left) takes you to your own home page as a user.

Open the manuals

- 1 Choose **Help** at the top right. Choose **Administrator Manual** (this one), **User Manual** (what your submitters and approvers see) or **How a request works (workflow)** - a two-page sheet that is handy for training.



RESULT

The manual opens in a new tab, where it can be searched, saved or printed. It is always the version that matches the system.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

A copied link to a manual stops working after a few minutes - open it again from **Help**.

Light or dark colours, and updates

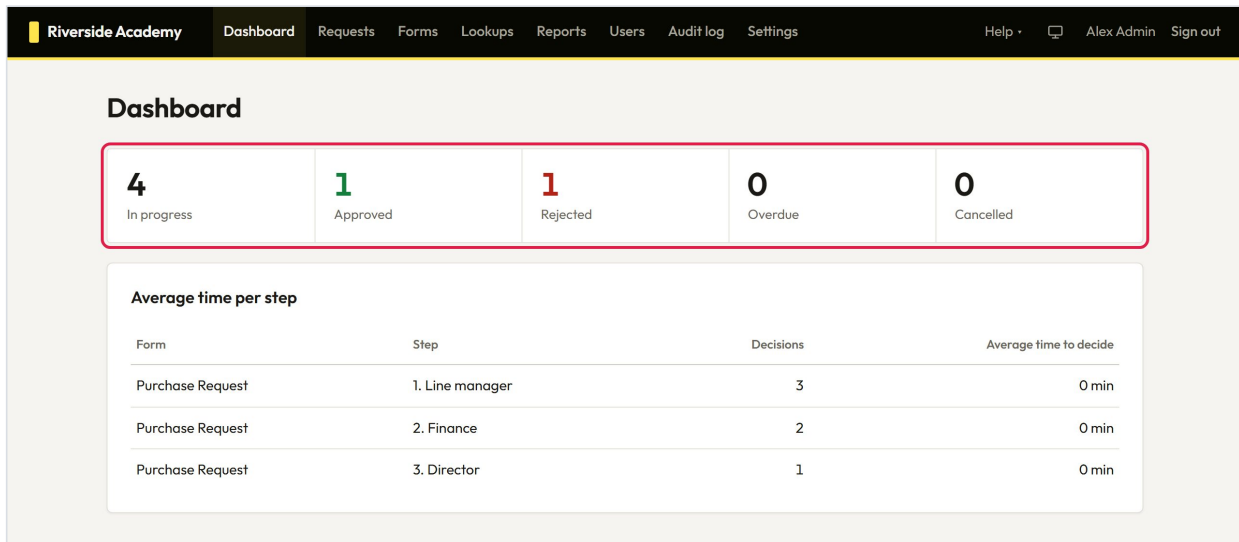
- The small screen icon next to **Help** switches between **System** (follow the computer), **Light** and **Dark**. It is each person's own choice.
- When a new version is installed, open pages show **A new version of FileBank WorkFlow is available** with a **Reload** button; the next page opened loads the new version by itself.

CHAPTER 3

Dashboard

Check how requests are doing

- 1 Choose **Dashboard**. Each tile counts requests; click a tile to open the request list filtered to it. Watch **Overdue** in particular.



- 2 Under **Average time per step**, see for each form and step how many decisions were made and how long they took on average. Use it to spot slow steps and to choose reminder periods.

Tile	Counts
In progress	Requests waiting on an approver, or sent back to the submitter for changes.
Approved	Requests approved at every step.
Rejected	Requests rejected at some step.
Overdue	In-progress requests whose current step has passed its due date (the step's "Remind after" days, or "Escalate after" if no reminder is set). Steps with neither never become overdue. Highlighted when above zero. Overdue is not a status: the request is still In progress.
Cancelled	Requests cancelled by an administrator.

IMPORTANT

A red banner on the dashboard means emails could not be delivered after 6 attempts. Check the mail server with your IT team, then open the request and choose **Resend** next to the failed email.

CHAPTER 4

Requests

Find a request

- 1 Choose **Requests**. Every request of your organisation is listed, newest first, 25 per page. Use the filters at the top and choose **Search**.

The screenshot shows the 'Requests' page in the Riverside Academy system. At the top is a navigation bar with links: Dashboard, Requests (active), Forms, Lookups, Reports, Users, Audit log, Settings, Help, Alex Admin, and Sign out. Below the navigation bar, the 'Requests' section has a red box highlighting the filter area. This area includes dropdowns for 'Form' (set to 'All'), 'Status' (set to 'All'), 'Submitter' (set to 'Anyone'), and 'Approver' (set to 'Anyone'). There are also 'From' and 'To' date pickers (format mm/dd/yyyy) and a yellow 'Search' button. To the right of the filters is an 'Export PDFs...' button. Below the filters is a table of requests:

Request	Form	Submitter	Submitted	Status	Progress
REQ-000006	Purchase Request	Sam Submitter	Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM	In progress	Step 2 of 3 · Frank Finance
REQ-000005	Purchase Request	Sam Submitter	Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM	In progress	Step 1 of 3 · Maria Manager
REQ-000004	Purchase Request	Sam Submitter	Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM	In progress	Step 1 of 3 · Maria Manager
REQ-000003	Purchase Request	Sam Submitter	Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM	In progress	Step 1 of 3 · Sam Submitter (sent back for changes)
REQ-000002	Purchase Request	Sam Submitter	Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM	Rejected	—
REQ-000001	Purchase Request	Sam Submitter	Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM	Approved	—

At the bottom of the table, there are 'Previous' and 'Next' buttons, and a page indicator 'Page 1 of 1 · 6 request(s)'.

- 2 Click a request number to open it.

RESULT

The filter is part of the page address, so you can bookmark or share a filtered list.

Filter	Finds
Search	The request number, the submitter's name or email, and the content of the submitted fields.
Form	One form, or all.
Status	In progress, Approved, Rejected, Cancelled, plus the view Overdue .
Submitter	Requests submitted by one person.
Approver	Requests where this person is assigned to, delegated on, or has decided any step. Use it before deactivating someone.
From / To	Submission date range (both days included).

The request page shows: **Actions** (the buttons below, and whether the PDF is stored); **Timeline** (the submission and each step - who it is assigned to, waiting since, due date, and once decided who acted, when, from which IP address, comments, signature and documents; a step that sent the request back shows each round in a purple box); **Emails** (each notification and its delivery status); and **Audit trail** (every event for this request).

Send a reminder

You need: a request that is in progress (not sent back - then it waits on the submitter).

- 1 Open the request and choose **Send reminder**.

Purchase Request

● In progress

REQ-000005

Submitted by Sam Submitter on Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM

Actions

Send reminder

Cancel request...

Download PDF

Timeline

Submitted

Sam Submitter · Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM

What do you need?

Science lab supplies

Business justification

Beakers, safety goggles and test tubes for the autumn term.

Estimated cost

312.50

Category

Other

Needed by

—

Urgent

No

Step 1: Line manager

Assigned to Maria Manager · waiting since Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM · due Oct 4, 2026, 2:50 PM

● Active

RESULT

The current approver (and delegate, if any) is emailed a reminder with a **fresh link**; their **earlier link** stops working. Use it when an approver says their link expired. People on the daily summary get it straight away too.

Reassign a step, or add a delegate

You need: a step that is Active, Waiting or Sent back.

- 1 Open the request. In the **Timeline**, choose **Reassign...** under the step and pick the new approver.

Timeline

Submitted
Sam Submitter · Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM

What do you need?	Business justification	Estimated cost	Category
Science lab supplies	Beakers, safety goggles and test tubes for the autumn term.	312.50	Other

Needed by: — Urgent: No

Step 1: Line manager ● Active
Assigned to Maria Manager · waiting since Oct 1, 2026, 2:50 PM · due Oct 4, 2026, 2:50 PM

Dana Director

☐ As delegate (keep Maria Manager too) **Save** **Cancel**

Step 2: Finance ○ Waiting
Assigned to Frank Finance
[Reassign...](#)

Step 3: Director ○ Waiting
Assigned to Dana Director
[Reassign...](#)

- 2 Leave **As delegate** unticked to **replace** the approver, or tick it to **add** a delegate while the original approver keeps the step.
- 3 Choose **Save**.

RESULT

If the step is active, the new person is emailed a link at once. Whoever decides first is recorded; the PDF and audit log show who actually acted.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

- Only active users with the Approver (or Admin) role are offered.
- This changes **this request only**. To change who approves future requests, publish a new version of the form's approval chain.

Cancel a request

- 1 Open the request and choose **Cancel request....** Type the reason (required) and choose **Confirm cancel**.

Actions

Send reminder **Cancel request...** Download PDF

Reason for cancelling *

Submitted twice - the same order is REQ-000004.

Cancelling is final. The submitter is notified and the approval link stops working.

Confirm cancel Back

RESULT

The request is **Cancelled**, which is final. Open steps close, approval links stop working and the submitter is emailed your reason. No PDF is made. Use it for duplicates or requests submitted by mistake.

Resend an email that failed

- 1 Open the request. In **Emails**, a failed message shows the error and a **Resend** link.
- 2 Choose **Resend** to queue the same message again. For an approval email prefer **Send reminder**, which has a fresh link.

Download a request's PDF

- 1 Open an approved or rejected request and choose **Download PDF**. The PDF exists within about a minute of the request closing.

Export many PDFs at once

You need: approved or rejected requests of one form - for an audit, payroll or a filing system.

- 1 On the **Requests** page choose **Export PDFs....**

- 2 Choose the **Form**, the **Submitted from** and **to** dates, and the **Outcome** (approved and rejected, approved only, or rejected only). Choose **Check**: it says how many PDFs match and the name of the ZIP.

Export PDFs

Close

One form's approved and/or rejected requests, by the date they were **submitted**: a ZIP with every PDF and an Excel file **Index.xlsx** listing each one - file name (a link to the PDF), request, status, people, dates, approval steps and the form's own fields. At most 500 PDFs at a time.

Form

Submitted from

to

Outcome

Purchase Request

10/01/2026

10/01/2026

Approved and rejected

2 PDFs will be exported as **Purchase-R_PDFs_01102026-01102026.zip**.

Check

Download ZIP

- 3 Choose **Download ZIP**. Hundreds of PDFs can take a minute; keep the page open.

RESULT

A ZIP with every PDF under its usual name, plus **Index.xlsx**: one row per PDF with the file name (a link that opens the PDF once the ZIP is unpacked), request, form, status, submitted by and when, decided, each approval step, rejection reason, and one column per form field.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

- At most **500 PDFs** per export. When more match, choose a shorter date range and export in parts.
- Requests in progress and cancelled ones have no PDF and are never included. A request that only just finished may not have its PDF yet - wait a minute.

CHAPTER 5

Forms and approval chains

A form has three parts, each with its own save button: **Details** (name, description, active), **Submission fields** (what the submitter fills in) and the **Approval chain** (who approves, in which order). Submitters see a form only when it is **Active** and has a **published chain**.

Create a form

- 1 Choose **Forms**. Under **New form** type a name and choose **Create and configure**.

Form	Status	Steps	Chain version	Requests	
IT Access & Equipment Request	Active	2	v1	0	Delete
Leave Request	Active	1	v1	0	Delete
Mileage Reimbursement	Active	2	v1	0	Delete
Purchase Request	Active	3	v1	6	Delete
Records Retrieval Request	Active	1	v1	0	Delete
Secure Destruction Authorization	Active	2	v1	0	Delete

New form

Form name, e.g. Travel Request **Create and configure**

Submitters only see a form once it has an approval chain.

Import an HTML form

Already have the form as a web page? Upload the `.html` file and its inputs, drop-downs, radio buttons, tick boxes and text areas become fields here. The file is only read for its fields – scripts and styling in it are ignored.

Choose HTML file... [or paste the HTML instead](#)

- 2 The form opens with one starter field, "Title". Add your fields (next tasks), then set up the approval chain and choose **Publish chain**.

RESULT

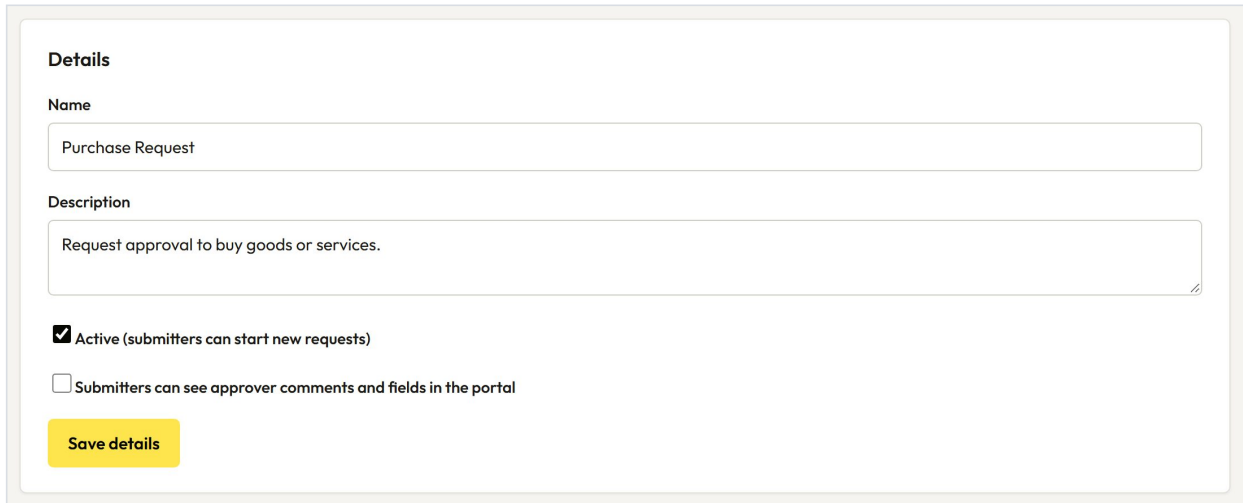
Once the chain is published, the form appears for submitters on their home page.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

The name must be different from your other forms.

Change a form's name, description or status

- 1 Choose **Forms** and click the form's name. Under **Details** change the **Name** and **Description** (shown to submitters).



The screenshot shows a 'Details' configuration panel for a form. It contains two text input fields: 'Name' with the value 'Purchase Request' and 'Description' with the value 'Request approval to buy goods or services.'. Below these fields are two checkboxes: 'Active (submitters can start new requests)' which is checked, and 'Submitters can see approver comments and fields in the portal' which is unchecked. A yellow 'Save details' button is located at the bottom of the panel.

- 2 Untick **Active** to stop new submissions (requests already in progress carry on). Tick **Submitters can see approver comments and fields in the portal** to show them more than each step's decision, approver and date.
- 3 Choose **Save details**.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

The PDF always contains the full record, including approver comments, and submitters can download their own PDF. If comments must stay confidential for a form, discuss it before go-live.

Add and arrange fields

- 1 Open the form. Under **Submission fields** the left side is a live preview of the form; the right side lists **Add a control**. Click a control (for example **+ Phone**) to add it at the end, or drag it onto the preview where you want it.

Submission fields

Design

Preview & test

What do you need? *

Business justification *

Estimated cost *

Category *

Select...

Needed by

mm/dd/yyyy

☐ Urgent

Add a control

TEXT

+ Text

+ Long text

+ Email

+ Phone

+ Web address

NUMBERS

+ Number

+ Currency

+ Slider

DATE & TIME

+ Date

+ Time

+ Date & time

+ Month

+ Week

CHOICES

+ Drop-down

+ Radio buttons

+ Tick boxes (many)

+ Single tick box

+ Lookup (Excel)

OTHER

+ Data grid

+ Colour

+ Signature (draw)

+ Signature (typed name)

LAYOUT

+ Heading

+ Paragraph

+ Picture

+ Divider

Click a control in the preview to edit it, drag it to move it, drag its right edge to resize, and

This preview is the layout submitters will see. Removing a control retires it: existing requests keep the data they were submitted with.

Save fields

- 2 Click a field in the preview to edit it. The right side shows its **properties**: label, width, required, help text, default value and more. Changes show at once. Choose **Done** to go back to the list of controls.

The screenshot shows the 'Submission fields' editor. On the left, under the 'Design' tab, is a preview of the form. It includes fields for 'What do you need?' (LONG TEXT - FULL), 'Business justification' (LONG TEXT - FULL), 'Estimated cost' (CURRENCY - FULL), 'Category' (SELECT), 'Needed by' (DATE), and 'Urgent' (CHECKBOX). The 'Estimated cost' field is selected, and its properties are shown on the right. The 'Currency properties' panel includes: Label (Estimated cost), WIDTH (Full), TEXT ALIGNMENT (Left), Control type (Currency), Required (checked), CALCULATED (unchecked), Placeholder, Help text, Default value, and Minimum/Maximum values (0.01).

- 3 To move a field, drag it - a blue bar shows where it will land. To resize it, drag its right edge (it snaps to a quarter, third, half... of the width). The small toolbar on a selected field moves it up or down, copies or deletes it.
- 4 Choose **Save fields**. Nothing changes for submitters until you save.

RESULT

New requests use the new fields. Requests already submitted keep the fields and labels they were submitted with.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

- Problems that block saving (a missing label, a duplicate key, a choice control without options) are listed under the builder.
- Removing a field **retires** it: old requests keep its data. Do not change the **Advanced > Key** of a field already in use - to the system that is a different field.

Work out a value from other fields

You need: a Number, Currency or Text field - for example a total.

- 1 Click the field. Under **Calculated** tick **Work this out from other fields** and type a **Formula** using the keys listed under it - here the total of two data grid columns, **trips.mileage + trips.tolls**.

The screenshot shows the 'Submission fields' panel on the left and the 'Currency properties' panel on the right. In the 'Submission fields' panel, the 'Total claim' field is highlighted with a yellow box. In the 'Currency properties' panel, the 'CALCULATED' section is expanded, and the 'Work this out from other fields' checkbox is checked. The formula 'trips.mileage + trips.tolls' is entered in the 'Formula' field and is highlighted with a red box. The 'Currency type' is set to 'Currency'.

- 2 Choose **Save fields**. Try it under **Preview & test** before people use it.

RESULT

On the form the box is read-only, marked **calculated**, and updates as people type. The server works it out again when the form is submitted, so nobody can type in a result of their own.

Add a table (data grid)

- 1 In the builder choose **+ Data grid** (under Other). It starts as a line-items table: Description, Quantity, Unit price and a calculated Amount with a total.

- 2 Click the grid. On the right, open each column to set its **Heading** and **Type** (Text, Number, Currency, Date, Time, Drop-down or **Calculated** with a formula), tick **Required in every row** or **Show a total under this column**, and set **Min. rows** / **Max. rows**.

Submission fields

Design Preview & test

Your name *

Month of travel *

Department *

Department code auto-filled

PARAGRAPH - FULL

Miles are reimbursed at \$0.70 per mile. Tolls and parking are paid at cost - keep the receipts, Finance may ask for them.

DATA GRID - FULL

Trips

#	DATE *	FROM *	TO *	PURPOSE	MILES *
1	mm/dd/yyyy				
Total					0

+ Add row

Total claim - calculated

☐ I certify these trips were for work, in my own vehicle, and are not claimed anywhere else *

Signature *

Undo Clear

Sign here with your finger, a stylus or the mouse

This preview is the layout submitters will see. Removing a control retires it: existing requests keep the data they were submitted with.

Save fields

Data grid properties Done

Label

Trips

WIDTH

Full

Control type

Data grid

☐ Required

COLUMNS

Date	Date
From	Text
To	Text
Purpose	Text
Miles	Number
Mileage \$	Calculated
Tolls / parking	Currency

+ Add column

- 3 Choose **Save fields**.

RESULT

People add as many rows as they need; calculated cells and totals update as they type and are worked out again by the server. The table appears in the approver's view, on the request page and in the PDF.

Set up the approval chain

- 1 Open the form and go to **Approval chain**. Choose **+ Add step** for each approval step; use the arrows to reorder and the cross to remove a step.

- 2 For each step type a **Step name** and choose **Who approves this step: Always the same person** (pick the approver) or **Chosen by** the submitter (step 1) or by the previous approver (later steps). Set the reminders and escalation.

- 3 Choose **Publish chain**.

RESULT

A **new version** of the chain is published. New requests use it; requests already in progress keep the version they started with (use **Reassign** to change those).

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

- Only active people with the Approver or Admin role can be chosen. A chain that names an inactive approver stops new submissions of that form.
- Escalation only **notifies**; it never reassigns.

Test the form and chain before people use it

- 1 Under **Approval chain** choose **Preview & test** (or the button on one step). Choose who it is **Submitted by**, fill in the form as the submitter sees it, and choose **Test submit**.

- 2 At each step you see the approver's screen: add a comment, draw a signature, pick the next approver if the step is chosen, and choose **Test approve and send on** - or **Test reject**...
- 3 At the end a summary shows who decided each step. Choose **Edit step N in Design** to fix something, or **Start again**.

RESULT

Nothing is saved: no request, no email, no audit entry, and nobody's account is created. The preview uses what is on your screen, including changes you have not saved or published. **Submission fields** has its own **Preview & test** to try just the form, lookups and calculations.

Import an existing HTML form

- 1 On the **Forms** page, under **Import an HTML form**, choose **Choose HTML file...** (up to about 1 MB), or **or paste the HTML instead** and **Read fields**.
- 2 Check the **Review the imported form** panel: correct names, labels, types and **Required**, reorder or remove fields, read the **Worth checking** notes. Nothing is saved yet.
- 3 Choose **Create form and add approval steps**, then set up the chain and choose **Publish chain**.

Pause or delete a form

- 1 To **pause** a form, open it, untick **Active** and choose **Save details**. This can be undone at any time.
- 2 To **delete** it, choose **Delete** in its row on the **Forms** page, read what will happen and choose **Delete form**.

RESULT

A form with no requests is deleted for good. A form with requests is removed from the list and from submitters, but its requests stay in **Requests** with their timeline, audit trail and PDFs; requests in progress carry on. Either way the name becomes free. Recorded as **form.deleted**.

Reference: controls

Control	Notes
Text, Long text	Up to 500 / 4,000 characters. Optional minimum and maximum length; Text can also have a pattern.
Email, Phone, Web address	Checked for the right shape. Web addresses must start with http:// or https://.
Number, Currency	Optional minimum, maximum and step. Currency is stored with two decimals.
Slider	A number chosen by sliding, 0 to 100 unless you set minimum and maximum.
Date, Time, Date & time, Month, Week	The browser's own pickers.
Drop-down, Radio buttons	One choice from your list of options (one per line).
Tick boxes (many)	Any number of choices; optional minimum and maximum number ticked.
Single tick box	Yes/No. If required, it must be ticked - use it for "I confirm..." statements.
Lookup (Excel)	A drop-down whose choices come from a lookup table; other fields can fill in from the chosen row (chapter Lookup tables).
Data grid	A table with rows people add, calculated columns and totals.
Colour	A colour picker; stored as a code such as #1d4ed8.

Control	Notes
Signature (draw)	A signing box for a finger, stylus or mouse, with Undo and Clear. Shown to approvers, on the request page and in the PDF.
Signature (typed name)	The person types their full name; account, time and IP address are recorded.
Heading, Paragraph, Divider, Picture	Layout only - never submitted or stored. A picture (PNG, JPG, GIF or WebP up to 300 KB) is not printed on the PDF.

Other properties: **Placeholder** (grey example text), **Help text** (a line under the field), **Width**, **Alignment** (headings, paragraphs, pictures) and **Text alignment** (inside typing boxes - right is useful for amounts), **Default value** (for a single tick box type yes; for tick boxes list options separated by commas; for dates YYYY-MM-DD). File uploads are not available for submitters.

Reference: formulas

Formula	Gives
quantity * unitPrice	Quantity times unit price.
items.amount + delivery	The total of the amount column of the data grid items , plus delivery.
subtotal * taxRate / 100	A percentage of another calculated field.
elapsed(timeIn, timeOut)	Hours between two times, also across midnight (22:00 to 06:00 is 8). Use this for timesheets.
elapsed(timeIn, timeOut) - breakHours	Hours worked across midnight, less a break (0.5 = half an hour).
round(total / 12, 2)	A monthly amount, rounded to 2 places.
max(nights - 1, 0) * allowance	Never below zero.
firstName & " " & upper.lastName)	Joins text: "Ada LOVELACE". Text goes in double quotes.
substring(code, 5, 4)	Four characters from the 5th: INV-2026-0042 gives 2026.
if(amount > 1000, "Director", "Manager")	Chooses between two results. Compare with = <> < > <= >=.
days(from, to) + 1	The days a leave request covers, both days included.

Functions

Numbers	sum, average, min, max, round(x, places), floor, ceiling, abs, mod(a, b), power(x, n)
Dates and times	days(from, to); elapsed(start, end). A time counts as hours (17:30 is 17.5).
Text	concat or &, substring (mid), left, right, upper, lower, trim, len, replace(text, find, with), text(number, places)
Logic	if(condition, then, otherwise)

- A formula can use any one-value field (a tick box is 1 or 0, a time is hours), other calculated fields, and a grid column's total written **grid.column**. Drawn signatures, tick boxes (many) and grids themselves cannot be used. Inside a data grid, only the functions round, min, max, abs and elapsed are available.
- An empty field counts as 0, but if every field a formula uses is empty the result stays empty. A missing time is never counted as midnight.
- Currency results have 2 decimals; for a number choose **Decimal places** (0 to 6). **Minimum** and **Maximum** apply to the result.
- The form cannot be saved while a formula uses an unknown key, uses itself, or two fields depend on each other.

Reference: approvers chosen from a list

For a step that is **Chosen by** someone, set **From: Everyone with the Approver role**, or **A lookup file** - an Excel list, imported on the Lookups page, with a column for each person's **sign-in email** and any other columns (school, name...). Choose the file, the **Column with their email**, optionally the **Column with their name**, and tick other columns to show beside the chosen person. Each step can use a different file.

- **The file decides who can be chosen.** Someone chosen who has no account gets one at that moment, with the Approver role (**user.created_from_list**); someone without the Approver role is given it (**user.role_granted**). They sign in the first time with an emailed code.
- Nobody can choose themselves, an approver cannot choose the submitter, deactivated people and rows without an email are not offered, and a request can always be rejected without choosing anybody.
- Each choice is recorded as **step.approver_chosen**. A file a step uses cannot be deleted, and **Replace data** refuses a file without the columns the step uses.

IMPORTANT

Because being in the file allows a person to approve, treat the file as a permission list. Only administrators can import or replace it, and every import is in the audit log.

Reference: approver signatures and documents

- Every step asks the approver to **draw a signature** before approving (not to reject). It is saved with the decision, shown to later approvers and administrators, and printed in the PDF.
- On every step the approver can **Attach documents** - PDF, Word, Excel, PowerPoint, text and images, up to **10 MB** each and **10 files** per step. They can remove them until they decide; after that nobody can. Later approvers and administrators can download them; the **submitter never sees them**, and they are not in the PDF.

Reference: sample forms

Five ready-made forms can be added to your organisation (ask your provider): **Leave Request** (lookup that fills in a department code, days worked out from two dates), **Mileage Reimbursement** (a trips table at \$0.70 a mile with totals, an "I certify" tick box, a drawn signature), **IT Access & Equipment Request** (the submitter picks their manager), **Records Retrieval Request** and **Secure Destruction Authorization**. They are ordinary forms: check their approvers, and untick **Active** or delete the ones you do not need.

Reference: PDF file names

[Form name, first 10 characters]_[request number without REQ-]_[date submitted, ddmmyyyy].pdf
 . Spaces become hyphens. Example: Purchase Request REQ-000045 submitted 5 November 2026 is **Purchase-R_000045_05112026.pdf**.

Reference: what an imported HTML form becomes

In the HTML	Becomes
Text and search inputs	Text (max length, pattern and placeholder kept)
Email, tel, url, date, time, datetime-local, month, week, color	The matching control
Number inputs	Number - or Currency when the step is 0.01 or the label mentions amount, cost, price, total
Range, text area, drop-down	Slider, Long text, Drop-down
Radio buttons sharing a name	Radio buttons (label from the fieldset legend)
One tick box / several sharing a name	Single tick box / Tick boxes (many)
File upload, password, hidden, disabled, buttons	Skipped (uploads and passwords listed under Worth checking)

CHAPTER 6

Lookup tables (Excel)

A lookup table is reference data you keep in Excel - schools and their secretaries, departments and their codes. Import it once, and any form can offer it in a drop-down and **fill in related boxes by itself**.

Import an Excel lookup table

You need: an .xlsx file: headings in the first row, one row per item, and one **key** column (the value people choose) that is filled in and never repeats. Up to 5,000 rows, 30 columns, 5 MB.

- 1 Choose **Lookups** and then **Choose .xlsx file....**

The screenshot shows the 'Lookups' section of the Riverside Academy interface. At the top is a navigation bar with links: Dashboard, Requests, Forms, **Lookups**, Reports, Users, Audit log, Settings, Help, Alex Admin, and Sign out. Below the navigation bar is the 'Lookups tables' section. It contains a table with the following data:

Name	Key column	Other columns	Rows	Used by	Updated	
Departments	Department	Department Code	5	Leave Request, Mileage Reimbursement, Records Retrieval Request, Secure Destruction Authorization	Oct 1, 2026, 3:07 PM	Replace data Delete
Job descriptions	Job Description	Account	5	not used	Oct 1, 2026, 3:07 PM	Replace data Delete
Schools	School	Department, Secretary, Email	8	IT Access & Equipment Request	Oct 1, 2026, 3:07 PM	Replace data Delete

Below the table is an 'Import an Excel file' section. It contains the text: 'Use the first row for column headings and one row per item - for example *School, Department, Secretary, Email*. Up to 5,000 rows, 30 columns, 5 MB. The first visible sheet is used.' Below this text is a button labeled 'Choose .xlsx file...' which is highlighted with a red rectangle in the original image.

- 2 Check the preview (sheet, number of rows, first rows). Nothing is saved yet.
- 3 Give the table a **name**, choose the **key column**, and choose **Import lookup table**.

RESULT

The table is listed with its rows and the forms that use it (**Used by**).

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

The message says why a file cannot be used - for example a repeated or missing key, two columns with the same heading, or a file that is not .xlsx (open .xls or .csv files in Excel and Save As .xlsx).

Use a lookup table on a form

- 1 In the form builder choose **+ Lookup (Excel)**, give it a label such as "School", and pick the **Lookup table** in its properties.
- 2 Add a Text, Email, Phone, Number or Currency field for each related value - for example "Secretary".
- 3 In that field's properties, under **Auto-fill from a lookup**, set **Follows** to the lookup and **Shows column** to the column. The preview marks it **auto-filled**.
- 4 Choose **Save fields**, then try it under **Preview & test**.

RESULT

On the form the auto-filled box is read-only and fills in as soon as a choice is made. The server works the values out again on submit, and they never change afterwards, even if the table does. Tables with more than 60 entries become a type-to-search box.

Change individual rows

- 1 On **Lookups** click the table's name. Use **Find a row** to search; choose **Edit** on a row, change it and choose **Save** - or **Delete**, then **Yes, delete**. Fill in **Add a row** at the bottom to add one.

Schools

Close

Find a row - type any part of any cell

Find

8 row(s).

School (key)	Department	Secretary	Email	
Hawes Elementary	Elementary	Pat Lee	pat.lee@example.org	Edit Delete
Orchard Elementary	Elementary	Sam Roy	sam.roy@example.org	Edit Delete
Ridge Elementary	Elementary	Ana Cruz	ana.cruz@example.org	Edit Delete
Somerville Elementary	Elementary	Lin Wu	lin.wu@example.org	Edit Delete
Travell Elementary	Elementary	Joe Hart	joe.hart@example.org	Edit Delete
Benjamin Franklin Middle School	Middle School	Dana Kim	dana.kim@example.org	Edit Delete
George Washington Middle School	Middle School	Omar Aziz	omar.aziz@example.org	Edit Delete
High School	High School	Rita Bell	rita.bell@example.org	Edit Delete

Add a row

School *

Department

Secretary

Email

School is the key: it must be filled in and be different from every other row. The other columns can be left empty.

Add row

Changes here apply to new requests at once. Requests already submitted keep the values they were given. Rows you add, change or delete here are not in your spreadsheet: **Replace data** puts the whole table back to what the file contains.

RESULT

Forms use the change at once; requests already submitted keep their values. Recorded as **lookup.row_added**, **row_updated** or **row_deleted**.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

Changes made here are not in your spreadsheet. **Replace data** puts the whole table back to the new file, so make the same changes in the spreadsheet first.

Replace a table with a new spreadsheet

- 1 On **Lookups** choose **Replace data** in the table's row and pick the new file.

RESULT

New requests use the new data at once; submitted requests keep their values.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

The file must still have every column that forms fill in from, or the message lists the missing columns and nothing changes. A table no form uses can be removed with **Delete**.

CHAPTER 7

Users

People get an account in two ways: they **sign in themselves** the first time with their work email (they get the Submitter role), or **you add them** with the roles they need. Either way each person chooses their own 6-digit key - you never see, set or send anyone's key.

Role	Gives access to
Submitter	Submitting forms and seeing their own requests.
Approver	Deciding steps assigned or delegated to them. Needed before someone can be named in a chain or a reassignment.
Admin	The administrator pages. Admins can also be approvers.

Add a person

- 1 Choose **Users**. Tick **Email each new person how to sign in** to send them a welcome email.
- 2 Under **One person** type their **Email** and **Name**, tick their roles and choose **Add person**.

Add people

☒ Email each new person how to sign in

ONE PERSON

Email

Name

☐ Admin ☒ Approver ☒ Submitter

Add person

MANY PEOPLE FROM EXCEL

A sheet with the headings **Email**, **Name** and **Roles** (Submitter, Approver or Admin; several separated by commas; empty means Submitter). People already in the list are skipped.

Download template

Choose File No file chosen

RESULT

They appear in the list as **No key yet** until they first sign in, confirm their email with a code and choose their key. Recorded as **user.created**.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

If allowed email domains are set, only addresses at those domains can be added.

Add many people from Excel

- 1 On **Users**, under **Many people from Excel**, choose **Download template**.
- 2 Fill in one row per person: **Email**, **Name** and **Roles** (Submitter, Approver or Admin; several separated by commas; empty means Submitter). Up to 1,000 rows.
- 3 Choose the file. The preview shows what will happen to each row - to add, already a user (skipped), or a problem (skipped).
- 4 Choose **Add N people**.

RESULT

Recorded as **users.imported** with the counts.

Change roles, or make someone an approver

- 1 On **Users** tick or untick the role boxes in the person's row. The change is saved at once, even for people who are signed in.

Name	Email	Roles	Status	Approval emails	Joined
Alex Admin	admin@riverside.test	☒ Admin ☐ Approver ☐ Submitter	Active	Each request	Oct 1, 2026
Dana Director	director@riverside.test	☐ Admin ☒ Approver ☒ Submitter	Active	Each request	Oct 1, 2026 Deactivate Reset password key
Frank Finance	finance@riverside.test	☐ Admin ☒ Approver ☐ Submitter	Active	Each request	Oct 1, 2026 Deactivate Reset password key
Maria Manager	manager@riverside.test	☐ Admin ☒ Approver ☐ Submitter	Active	Each request	Oct 1, 2026 Deactivate Reset password key
Sam Submitter	submitter@riverside.test	☐ Admin ☐ Approver ☒ Submitter	Active	Each request	Oct 1, 2026 Deactivate Reset password key

RESULT

A new approver can be chosen in an approval chain or a reassignment straight away, even before their first sign-in.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

Everyone keeps at least one role, and you cannot remove your own Admin role.

Reset someone's password key

You need: a person who cannot use **Forgot your key?** on the sign-in page themselves.

- 1 Make sure the request really comes from that person (call them back, or ask in person).
- 2 On **Users** choose **Reset password key** in their row and confirm.

RESULT

Their old key stops working and they are signed out everywhere. Next time they sign in they get an emailed code and choose a new key. Roles, requests and approvals are kept. Recorded as **user.key_reset**.

When someone leaves

- 1 Choose **Requests**, filter **Approver** by the person, and **Reassign** each open step.
- 2 Open each form whose chain names them and publish a new chain without them.
- 3 On **Users** choose **Deactivate** in their row.

RESULT

They are signed out everywhere and cannot sign in or register again with that address. Their history is kept. **Reactivate** restores access with the same roles and key.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

If they still have open steps, a message tells you how many. While a chain names an inactive approver, new submissions of that form are refused.

Reference: Status and Approval emails columns

Status	Meaning
Active	Has a password key and can sign in.
No key yet	Added by you, or reset, and has not signed in to choose a key yet.
Locked	Five wrong keys in a row. Unlocks by itself after 15 minutes; a reset also clears it.
Inactive	Deactivated. Cannot sign in or register again with that address.

Approval emails shows each person's own choice: **Each request** (the default) or **Daily summary** at the hour shown, in their own time zone (hover to see which) - one email each weekday listing everything waiting. You can see it but not change it.

CHAPTER 8

Reports

Build and run a report

- 1 Choose **Reports**. Under **New report on the form**, choose the form.
- 2 Under **One row for each** choose **Request**, or - if the form has a data grid - **Line of the data grid**.
- 3 Under **Columns** choose a column to add and **Add** (request number, status, people, dates, any form field, any approver field, grid totals); use the arrows to order them. Under **Filters** set dates, status and conditions. Choose **Run report**.

New report · Purchase Request Close

COLUMNS

1. Request number · Request ↑ ↓ ×
2. Status · Request ↑ ↓ ×
3. Submitted · Request ↑ ↓ ×

Choose a column to add... ▼ Add

FILTERS

Submitted from

mm/dd/yyyy 📅

Submitted to

mm/dd/yyyy 📅

Status: ☐ In progress ☐ Approved ☐ Rejected ☐ Cancelled (all)

+ Add a filter

GROUP AND SUMMARISE

Group by

No grouping - one row each ▼

Sort by

Newest request first ▼

Run report

Export to Excel

Export to CSV

Name, to save this report

Save report

- 4 The result appears below, newest first, with every number column totalled. Choose **Export to Excel** or **Export to CSV** for a file.

Result		
6 requests.		
Request number	Status	Submitted
REQ-000006	InProgress	10/01/2026 2:50 PM
REQ-000005	InProgress	10/01/2026 2:50 PM
REQ-000004	InProgress	10/01/2026 2:50 PM
REQ-000003	InProgress	10/01/2026 2:50 PM
REQ-000002	Rejected	10/01/2026 2:50 PM
REQ-000001	Approved	10/01/2026 2:50 PM

RESULT

Up to 5,000 rows on screen; exports always contain every row. Exports are recorded as **report.exported**.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

One run reads up to the newest 20,000 requests - narrow the dates or status if the page says it stopped there.

Group and summarise

- 1 Under **Group by** choose a column - one row per department, school or status, with how many each has. For a date, choose per day, week, month or year.
- 2 For each other column choose **Total**, **Average**, **Lowest**, **Highest** or **Count**. Choose **Run report**; a bar chart shows the first summary.

Example	How
Spend per department this year	Columns: Department, Amount. Filter: submitted from 1 January. Group by Department.
Requests still waiting, and where	Filter: status In progress. Group by Waiting at step.
Every purchase over 1,000	Filter: Amount is more than 1000.

Save a report to run again

- 1 Type a **name** and choose **Save report**. Saved reports are listed at the top for every administrator; open one to run it with today's data.
- 2 To change one, choose **Edit** beside it, make the change and choose **Save changes** (or **Save as a new report**).

Hours report (timesheets)

You need: a timesheet form: a data grid with a date column and Time In / Time Out (or Worked Hour) columns.

- 1 On **Reports** switch to **Hours**. Choose the **Form** and the **Submitter** (or **All submitters**).
- 2 Choose **Single day**, or **Date range** (or **This week**, **Last week**, **This month**, **Last month**). Dates are the days worked, not the day submitted.
- 3 Only approved timesheets count; tick **Also count timesheets still waiting for approval** to include those. Optionally tick up to 10 **Extra columns from the form** such as Employee ID.
- 4 Choose **Run report**, then **Export to Excel** or **Export to CSV**.

RESULT

One person: their lines in date order with total hours and days. All submitters: grouped per person with subtotals and a grand total. Hours have 2 decimals (7.50 is seven and a half hours).

TIP

Reports show dates as **MM/DD/YYYY** and times as **h:mm AM/PM**, on screen and in Excel and CSV, in the time zone of your computer. Renamed fields keep their history; removed fields appear marked (retired).

CHAPTER 9

Audit log

Every change is recorded with the **user**, **time (UTC)** and **IP address**: sign-ins, submissions, decisions, reassignments, reminders, cancellations, configuration and user changes, PDFs, downloads and exports. Nobody can edit or delete an entry.

Find out who did what

- 1 Choose **Audit log**. Filter by **Event contains** (for example step. or auth.login), **User** and dates, and choose **Filter**. Hover over a row for its detail; click a request number to open the request.

Time	Event	Change	Request	User	IP
Oct 1, 2026, 3:15 PM	auth.login			Alex Admin	::1
Oct 1, 2026, 3:15 PM	auth.login			Sam Submitter	::1
Oct 1, 2026, 3:15 PM	auth.login			Alex Admin	::1
Oct 1, 2026, 3:15 PM	auth.login			Sam Submitter	::1
Oct 1, 2026, 3:14 PM	auth.login			Alex Admin	::1
Oct 1, 2026, 3:14 PM	auth.login			Sam Submitter	::1
Oct 1, 2026, 3:12 PM	auth.login			Alex Admin	::1
Oct 1, 2026, 3:12 PM	auth.login			Sam Submitter	::1
Oct 1, 2026, 3:09 PM	auth.login			Alex Admin	::1

- 2 Choose **Export CSV** to download everything that matches the filter (not just the page shown), with email, browser and full detail.

RESULT

The export is itself recorded. Values a spreadsheet could read as a formula start with an apostrophe.

Reference: events

Event	Meaning
auth.login / login_failed / logout	Sign-in activity.
auth.account_locked / login_blocked_locked	Fifth failure locked the account / attempt while locked.
auth.refresh_reuse_detected	An old session token was replayed; that user's sessions were ended. Investigate if unexpected.
auth.account_created / key_created	Someone registered at first sign-in / created a new key after a reset.
auth.password_changed, key_reset_requested, key_reset_self	A user changed their key / asked for a forgotten-key code / chose a new key with it.
request.submitted / approved / rejected / cancelled	Request lifecycle, with from and to states.
step.activated / approved / rejected	Step lifecycle. Detail shows asDelegate, viaLink, selfApproval, inBatch and dailySummary when they apply.
step.returned / request.resubmitted	Sent back for changes (with the reason) / resubmitted (with the changed fields).
step.reassigned / delegated / approver_chosen	An administrator changed who can act / an approver was picked from a list.
step.reminder_sent / escalated	Reminder or escalation (user "System" when automatic).
approval.link_opened	An approver opened their emailed link.
attachment.added / removed / downloaded	Approver documents.
archive.pdf_stored, pdf.downloaded, pdf.exported	A closed request's PDF was stored / downloaded / exported in a ZIP ("changedBy" names a provider administrator who did it).
report.exported / saved / updated / deleted, audit.exported	Reports and log exports.
lookup.imported / replaced / deleted / row_added / row_updated / row_deleted	Lookup table changes.
form.created / updated / fields_updated / deleted, form.import_parsed, chain.published	Form configuration.
user.created / users.imported / updated / key_reset / created_from_list / role_granted / preferences_changed	People and their roles, keys and email choices.

Event	Meaning
notification.failed / requeued	An email was given up on / queued again.
settings.updated	A setting changed (names only, never values).
user.impersonation_started, tenant.*	A provider administrator started a support session / set up, renamed, suspended or reactivated your organisation.

selfApproval marks a step where the approver is also the submitter (allowed, and flagged for review).
impersonatedByPlatformAdmin means the action was done during a provider support session.

CHAPTER 10

PDF archive and notifications

The PDF of each request

When a request is approved or rejected, a PDF of the complete record - every step, comment and **signature** - is made within about 15 seconds and kept in the database (or in your organisation's own file folder). Every page starts with your **logo and display name** and a green **APPROVED** or red **REJECTED** badge. Administrators, the submitter and that request's approvers can download it. A stored PDF can never be changed or deleted.

Your own file folder: your provider can save your PDFs and approver documents as ordinary files in a folder of your own, grouped **one folder per day submitted** (2026-09-28). The app keeps a fingerprint of every file and refuses one that was changed outside it. Only files saved after the folder was set up go there.

Emails

Email	To	Sent when
Submission received	Submitter	A request is submitted.
Approval needed	Approver	Their step becomes active. Lists the details (unless turned off in Settings) with Approve, Send back and Reject buttons.
Changes needed	Submitter	An approver sends the request back.
Resubmitted for approval	The approver who sent it back	The submitter resubmits; lists what changed.
Approval needed (reassigned)	New approver or delegate	An admin reassigns or delegates an active step.
Reminder	Approver and delegate	Send reminder, or the reminder rule is due.
Daily summary	Approvers who chose it	Monday to Friday at their chosen hour, when anything waits. Replaces their per-request and scheduled reminder emails.
Escalation	Escalation person or admins	The step passes its "Escalate after" days. Once per step.
Rejected / Fully approved / Cancelled	Submitter (rejections also to admins)	The request closes.
Verification code	The person signing in	First sign-in, Forgot your key?, or after a reset.

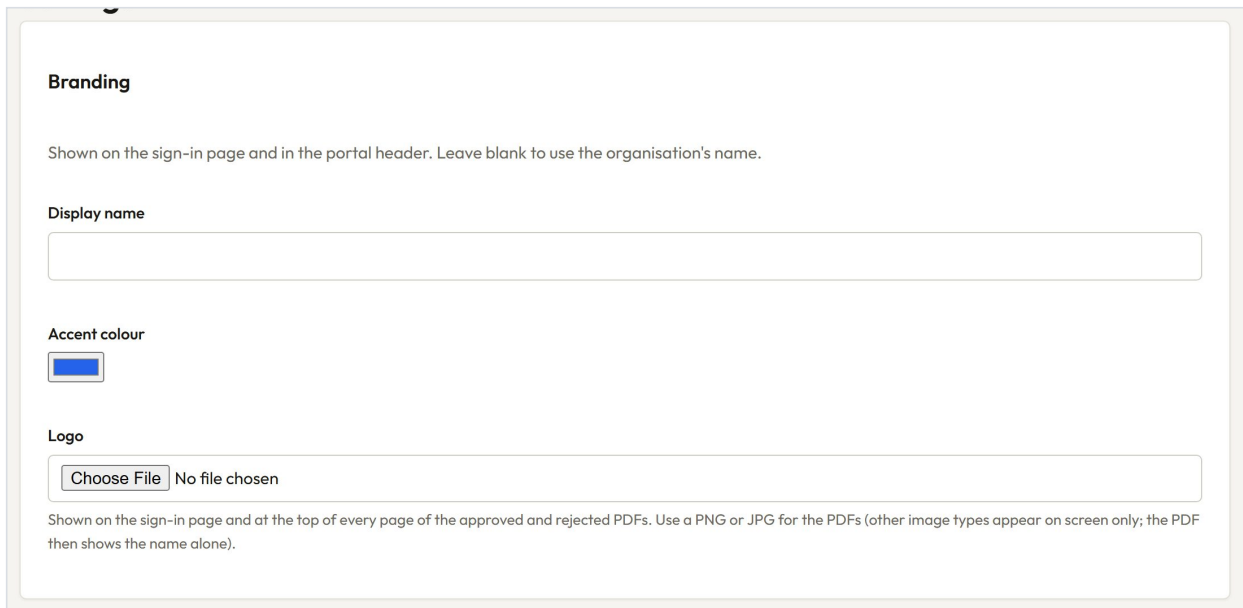
Emails go out within about 10 seconds. A failed send is retried after 1, 5, 15, 60 and 180 minutes, then marked Failed on the dashboard. Reminders and escalations are checked every 5 minutes, in calendar days from when the step became active. "Administrators" means your admin notification address if one was set, otherwise every active admin.

CHAPTER 11

Settings

Change your name, logo or colour

- 1 Choose **Settings**. Under **Branding** set the **Display name** (sign-in page, header and PDFs), the **Accent colour** and the **Logo** (under 300 KB, about 200 x 48 pixels; PNG or JPG so it also prints on the PDFs).



- 2 Choose **Save settings** at the bottom.

RESULT

Everyone sees the change at once. PDFs use the branding as it is when each request closes.
Recorded as **settings.updated**.

Decide who can register

- 1 Under **Who can register**, type the **Allowed email domains** separated by commas (for example acme.com, acme.co.uk); blank allows any address the installation allows.
- 2 Leave **Email verification at first sign-in** on.
- 3 Choose **Save settings**.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

With verification off, anyone who knows a colleague's address could claim that account before its owner signs in. Domains do not affect existing accounts or approvers created from a lookup list.

Change the email sender, or hide details in emails

- 1 Under **Email sender** set the **From name** and **From address**. Ask your IT team first: a mail server normally refuses to send as an address it is not allowed to.
- 2 Untick **Show the request's details in approval emails** if your forms hold information that should not travel by email (salaries, health or ID details). The Approve, Send back and Reject buttons stay.
- 3 Choose **Save settings**.

TIP

A blank setting means **use the installation default**; the page shows what that is.

CHAPTER 12

Common tasks and troubleshooting

Situation	What to do
An approver has left	Requests > filter Approver > Reassign each open step. Forms > publish a chain without them. Users > Deactivate .
An approver is on leave	Add a delegate on their open steps (Reassign... with As delegate ticked). For long absences publish a chain naming the stand-in.
Approver says the link does not work	Check they sign in with the right account; Send reminder issues a fresh link. They can also open it from Waiting for my approval.
Approver did not get the email	Open the request > Emails : if Sent, ask them to check junk mail; if Failed, fix the cause and Resend , then Send reminder .
User forgot their key	Point them to Forgot your key? . If they cannot receive the email: Users > Reset password key .
User cannot sign in	Locked: wait 15 minutes or use Forgot your key?. Inactive: Reactivate . No codes arriving for anyone: the mail server needs IT.
Someone must approve but is not in the approver list	Users > tick Approver for them (or add them with Approver ticked).
Request submitted by mistake	Cancel request... with a reason.
Sent back for changes for a long time	It waits on the submitter, so no reminders go out. Contact them, or cancel the request.
"This form has been deleted" on resubmit	Cancel the request; they submit a new one on another form.
Submitter wants a rejection reversed	Not possible. They start a new request; the rejected request can pre-fill it.
Wrong approver on in-flight requests after a chain change	Expected: in-flight requests keep their chain. Reassign those steps.
Form missing for submitters	It must be Active with a published chain of active approvers.
Need evidence of who did what	Audit log > filter > Export CSV , and the request's PDF.

Security reminders

- Give the Admin role sparingly and review the user list regularly. Deactivate leavers the same day.
- Never ask anyone for their password key or verification code - you never need them.

- Treat **auth.refresh_reuse_detected** and bursts of **auth.login_failed** in the audit log as worth a look.
- Exports and PDFs contain personal and business data. Store them according to your organisation's policy.